

How Much Should a Deck Cost to Build in 2026? Real Prices Per Square Foot

Meta Title: Deck Building Cost 2026: Real Prices Per Square Foot (Wood vs Composite) Meta Description: Planning a deck? See actual cost breakdowns for materials, labor, permits, and installation. Compare wood vs composite decking with regional price adjustments.

You want a deck. You've measured the space. You've imagined summer evenings out there. Now you need to know: **what's this actually going to cost?**

National averages say "\$30-\$60 per square foot"—but that range is so wide it's basically useless. Let's get specific.

The Quick Numbers

For a **300 sqft deck** (10' x 30', typical size):

Material Type	DIY Cost	Pro Install	Total (Pro)
Pressure-treated wood	\$4,500-6,000	\$3,600-4,500	\$8,100-10,500
Cedar/Redwood	\$7,500-9,000	\$3,900-4,800	\$11,400-13,800
Composite (mid-grade)	\$9,000-12,000	\$4,200-5,400	\$13,200-17,400
Composite (premium)	\$12,000-15,000	\$4,500-6,000	\$16,500-21,000
PVC/vinyl	\$13,500-16,500	\$4,800-6,300	\$18,300-22,800

Includes: Framing, joists, decking, railings, stairs, hardware, labor. Does NOT include: Permits, site prep, electrical, or water features.

Cost Breakdown: What You're Actually Paying For

1. Materials (50-60% of total cost)

Framing & Structure (\$8-12/sqft)

- **Pressure-treated lumber for joists:** \$1.50-2.50/linear foot (2x8)
- **Posts (4x4 or 6x6):** \$12-35 each
- **Beams (2x10 or larger):** \$15-40 per beam
- **Concrete footings:** \$8-15 per footing (you'll need 8-12 for a 300 sqft deck)
- **Joist hangers, bolts, brackets:** \$200-400 for typical deck

What's fair: Framing should account for roughly 30-35% of your material cost.

Red flag: If a quote says "structure included" with no itemization, ask for specifics. Under-

engineered framing is a safety hazard.

Decking Surface (\$4-25/sqft)

Material	Cost/sqft	Lifespan	Maintenance
Pressure-treated pine	\$4-7	15-20 yrs	High (annual sealing)
Cedar	\$8-12	20-25 yrs	Medium (stain every 2-3 yrs)
Redwood	\$10-15	25-30 yrs	Medium
Composite (Trex, TimberTech)	\$10-18	25-30 yrs	Low (clean annually)
PVC (Azek, Fiberon)	\$15-25	30+ yrs	Very low
Ipe/tropical hardwood	\$18-30	30-50 yrs	Low-medium

Pro tip: Budget composite decking often uses cheaper materials that fade faster. Mid-grade composite (\$12-15/sqft) is the sweet spot for value.

Railings & Stairs (\$1,500-5,000 total)

Railing costs (per linear foot): - Pressure-treated wood balusters: \$20-35/ft - Composite with aluminum balusters: \$50-80/ft - Cable railing (stainless steel): \$60-100/ft - Glass panel railing: \$150-300/ft

Stairs: - 3-4 step staircase (pressure-treated): \$400-700 - 5-6 step staircase (composite): \$800-1,400

Code requirement: Most jurisdictions require railings if the deck is more than 30" above grade. Budget for it.

2. Labor (30-40% of total cost)

Deck building labor rates (2026):

Region	Low (\$/hr)	Average (\$/hr)	High (\$/hr)
Midwest, South	\$35	\$50	\$65
Mountain West	\$40	\$60	\$80
Northeast, Pacific NW	\$50	\$75	\$100
CA, NYC metro	\$65	\$90	\$130

Typical crew: 2-3 workers for 3-5 days (depending on size and complexity).

What's fair: For a 300 sqft deck, expect 60-100 labor hours total (\$3,000-7,500 depending on region).

Red flag: If labor is quoted at less than 25% of total cost, the contractor may be: - Planning to cut corners - Using inexperienced crew - Underestimating complexity (change orders coming later)

3. Permits & Fees (5-10% of total cost)

Don't skip permits. Seriously.

Permit Type	Typical Cost
Building permit	\$150-500
Engineering/structural review	\$300-800 (if required)
HOA approval	\$0-200 (some HOAs charge admin fees)

Why it matters: - Un-permitted decks must often be torn down when discovered - Affects home insurance coverage - Becomes a liability when selling - Can void warranties on materials

What's fair: Contractor should pull permits and include cost in quote. If they suggest skipping permits "to save money," walk away.

4. Site Prep & Extras

These are often NOT included in base quotes:

Item	Cost
Grading/leveling site	\$500-2,000
Removing old deck	\$800-2,500
Tree/stump removal	\$300-1,500 per tree
Electrical (outlets, lighting)	\$1,000-3,500
Built-in seating/planters	\$500-2,000
Pergola or shade structure	\$2,000-8,000
Skirting (to hide under-deck)	\$3-8/linear foot

Pro tip: Get these in writing BEFORE work starts. "Oh, we'll need to do X" after demo begins is how budgets blow up.

Real Example: 300 sqft Composite Deck

Project: Ground-level deck (12' x 25'), composite decking, aluminum balusters, 4-step staircase.

Location: Columbus, OH (mid-cost region)

Material Breakdown

Item	Quantity	Unit Cost	Total
Concrete footings (12)	12	\$12	\$144
4x4 posts	8	\$18	\$144
2x8 joists (12' long)	28	\$16	\$448

2x10 beams (14' long)	4	\$38	\$152
Joist hangers, bolts, brackets	-	-	\$280
Composite decking (Trex Enhance)	325 sqft	\$12	\$3,900
Composite railing system	50 linear ft	\$65	\$3,250
Staircase (4 steps, composite)	1	\$900	\$900
Fasteners, screws, hidden clips	-	-	\$350
Materials Subtotal			\$9,568

Labor

- 2-person crew, 4 days (64 hours @ \$55/hr avg): **\$3,520**

Permits & Fees

- Building permit: **\$225**

Total: \$13,313

Per square foot: \$44.38

How to Tell If Your Deck Quote Is Fair

1. Check the material markup

Contractors typically mark up materials by 10-20%. You can verify retail prices: - Lowe's/Home Depot for common materials - Local lumber yards for framing - Manufacturer websites for composite decking MSRP

Red flag: Material costs 40%+ above retail (unless it's specialized/custom product).

2. Verify labor hours match scope

Deck Size Typical Labor Hours

100-200 sqft 30-50 hours

200-300 sqft 50-80 hours

300-400 sqft 70-100 hours

400+ sqft 90-130+ hours

Add hours for: - Complex shapes (angles, curves, multiple levels): + 20-40% - Elevated decks (8' + above grade): + 30-50% - Stairs, built-ins, pergolas: + 15-30% each

3. Compare apples to apples

When comparing three quotes:

✓ **Do:** - Confirm same decking material (or equivalent grade) - Verify same railing style - Check if permits are included - Ask if stairs are included - Confirm warranty coverage

✗ **Don't:** - Compare PT wood quote to composite quote - Assume "same" materials without brand/model names - Ignore differences in railing quality

4. Watch for lowball traps

If one quote is 30%+ cheaper than others:

Possible explanations: - Different materials (PT wood vs composite, or lower-grade composite) - Thinner joists/wider spacing (not to code) - Skipping permits - Inexperienced crew - Planning to upsell with change orders

What to ask: - "What joist spacing are you using?" (16" on-center is standard, 24" is weaker) - "What fastener type?" (hidden clips cost more but look better) - "Are permits included?" - "What's your warranty on workmanship?"

Regional Price Adjustments

Multiply base costs by these factors:

Region	Multiplier
Rural Midwest/South	0.85x
Mid-size cities	1.0x (baseline)
Denver, Seattle, Portland	1.15x
Boston, DC, Philadelphia	1.25x
San Francisco Bay Area	1.45x
New York City metro	1.55x

Example: A \$12,000 deck in Columbus, OH would cost ~\$17,400 in Boston, or ~\$18,600 in SF.

What's NOT Included in Most Quotes

Unless explicitly stated, assume these are extra:

- Gas/water line relocation
- Irrigation system adjustments
- Landscaping around deck
- Outdoor kitchen/BBQ hookups
- Hot tub reinforcement (requires extra structural support)
- Snow load engineering (in heavy snow regions)

Pro tip: Ask for a written scope of work that lists what IS and ISN'T included.

When to DIY vs Hire a Pro

DIY makes sense if:

- You have carpentry experience
- You own/can borrow necessary tools (circular saw, drill, level, post-hole digger)
- The deck is ground-level (< 30" high, no railings required)
- You have time (20-40 hours for a 200 sqft deck)
- You're comfortable pulling permits and arranging inspections

Savings: 30-40% on labor (but factor in tool costs and your time).

Hire a pro if:

- Deck is elevated (safety risk if framing fails)
- Local code is complex
- You need engineering (steep slope, heavy snow loads)
- You want warranty protection
- Your time is worth more than \$40-60/hr

Questions to Ask Before You Sign

1. **"Can I see the itemized material list with brands/models?"**
 2. If they won't provide it, walk away.
 3. **"What's your payment schedule?"**
 4. Standard: 10-20% deposit, 40% at demo/framing, 40% at completion.
 5. Red flag: 50%+ upfront.
 6. **"Are permits included?"**
 7. If no, get permit cost estimate in writing.
 8. **"What warranty do you offer on workmanship?"**
 9. Industry standard: 1-2 years on labor.
 10. **"What's your joist spacing and beam size?"**
 11. Should match local code (typically 16" on-center for joists).
 12. **"Do you carry general liability and workers' comp insurance?"**
 13. Ask for proof. If they're uninsured and someone gets hurt, you're liable.
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How Ungouge.ai Can Help

Instead of guessing whether your deck quote is fair, **upload it to Ungouge.ai**.

Our analysis includes: - ✓ Material cost verification against regional pricing data - ✓ Labor hour estimates for your deck size and complexity - ✓ Code compliance check (joist spacing, footing depth, railing requirements) - ✓ Markup analysis (is the contractor's margin reasonable?) - ✓ Red flag detection (missing items, vague descriptions, inflated labor)

Cost: \$19.99 for a detailed report. No lead gen. No contractor referrals. Just data.

[Get your deck quote analyzed →](#)

Bottom Line

For a typical **300 sqft composite deck** with railings and stairs: - **Budget range:** \$12,000-17,000 (including labor, materials, permits) - **Cost per sqft:** \$40-57

If your quote is significantly higher, it should include: - Premium materials (high-end composite, cable/glass railings) - Complex design (multi-level, curves, built-ins) - Difficult site conditions (steep slope, limited access) - Regional cost adjustment (high-cost metro area)

If it's higher without those factors, you're likely being overcharged.

Upload your quote to find out.

Last updated: February 2026 Data sources: RSMeans 2026, NADRA 2025 Cost Survey, regional contractor interviews